

1 UP / 2 DN

In its long and varied career, the train 1 Up / 2 Dn has been known by many names. It used to be the East Indian Railway Mail when it was run by the East Indian Railway (EIR) and began operations in 1866, connecting the capital Calcutta with Delhi via Benaras, Lucknow, Cawnpore, and Agra. Most importantly, though, it was the chosen mode of transportation for British officials to make their way to and from Simla (now Shimla), the summer capital.

While once this rail route ended in Delhi, the Scinde, Punjab and Delhi Railway (SPDR) extended the line towards Umballa (present-day Ambala, Haryana) in 1870, making the journey to Simla easier. Realizing the interests of private companies in the region, the Government of India passed a resolution in 1887 that allowed private companies to construct a line from Umballa to Kalka in the Himalayan foothills, and later to Simla in 1903. Construction started in 1889 and two years later, the Delhi–Umballa–Kalka Railway (DUK) Company opened a line to Kalka. The train now came to be known as the “Howrah–Kalka Mail” as it carried not just people, but also postal mail. The line was instantly popular as officials, administrators, army officers, and even tourists, could travel all the way to Kalka where the line terminated. They would then take tongas (horse-drawn carriages) up to Simla – a 93-km-journey that would take another eight hours.

Colloquially called the Kalka Mail today, it is the oldest mail train in India and was considered the fastest until the introduction of the [Rajdhani Express](#) in 1969. This iconic train even made an appearance in writer and film-maker Satyajit Ray’s short story, “Incident on the Kalka Mail”. The train also contributed to a memorable moment in the history of independent India when, in 1948, it was rushed from Howrah to Delhi to carry Mahatma Gandhi’s ashes to Prayag to be immersed in the River Ganges.